

stone-collector-birthday- adventure

version 1

This copy carries no dedication.

Contents

1. The Tenth Birthday

The people and the places

Characters

No characters in this novel.

Places

No places in this novel.

Chapter 1 — The Tenth Birthday

Leo woke on the morning he turned ten, and the first thing he noticed was Bruno. The scruffy terrier sat rigid at the foot of the bed, ears pointed toward the window, not doing his usual stretch-and-pad-to-the-kitchen. His whole body was trembling slightly, as if he'd heard something the rest of the world hadn't.

"Bruno?" Leo said. "You okay?"

The dog turned to look at him once, then back at the window. He didn't bark. He didn't whine. He just... stayed there, worried.

Leo had been awake most of the night anyway. Something strange had been dancing on the rocks the night before—a light, flickering and impossible to look away from. He'd watched it until nearly midnight, when his eyes had finally won the battle against his will to keep watching. Even then, sleep hadn't come easy.

But today he was ten. That felt important enough to get up.

Pau was waiting in the kitchen with his slow smile, the kind that took a moment to arrive on his face but meant something real. "Morning, ten-year-old," he said. "High tide came and went at eight-thirty—my father taught me to read the table before I was your age. Come on. I want to show you something."

They walked to the garden where, two months earlier, they had built the cardboard observatory together. The roof opening faced straight up at the blue sky, and when Leo lay inside it, the garden fell silent beyond the cardboard. It was just him and the sky, and the warm cardboard against his shoulders.

Pau lay down first—carefully, the way his knees asked him to—and Leo slid in beside him. The cardboard walls smelled like dried glue and adventure.

"Look," Pau said, pointing up through the opening. "That's what I wanted you to see."

It was just blue. Empty blue, all the way up. But Pau was pointing at one particular piece of it, the way you point at a friend's house, and Leo understood that something was up there whether he could see it or not.

Back inside, Pau handed him a small book with a worn cover. A constellation guide. Inside the front cover, in Pau's handwriting, were five careful lines:

For your tenth birthday. The observatory is a time machine—to see the past and future of the stars. Every light up there burned for years before we were born, and will keep burning long

after. Learn them. They're the same ones I learned.

Leo sat in the afternoon light and held the book carefully, then reached under his bed for his collection. Captain Crunch came out first—the fossil from the beach, small enough to fit in his palm, a pale spiral with one smooth face and one rough. The smooth stones followed: the grey ones, the amber ones, the small black beach stone Ava had found with him in July. He arranged them by size, then by colour, then by the feeling of them under his thumb.

But he was still searching for one perfect white stone. The right one hadn't shown up yet.

Around half past two, while arranging and rearranging, he glanced toward the window. The rocks at the town's edge were catching the light in a strange way—or something on them was. A flicker. A glow.

What was that?